

Stanford - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | ACC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Clear Power-4 underdog with a credible defensive core, but the offense must make a substantial efficiency leap simply to reach average functionality.
Preseason consensus	AP unranked , zero votes · ACC media ACC media 17th · SP+ No. 79
Returning production	60% (No. 36) overall · Off. 58% (No. 54) · Def. 62% (No. 23)
Primer power rating	-2.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	3.8 wins · likely 4-8
Net vs. 2025	● ↔ Similar overall, with a modest chance to improve on offense if the new structure creates more explosives
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: HC Tavita Pritchard calls a tempo/motion offense with QB Davis Warren named the opener starter. DC Kris Richard builds the more trustworthy defense around ILB Matt Rose and explosive-play prevention.

Bottom line: Stanford can be more coherent without becoming good overnight; bowl relevance requires a major offensive efficiency jump while the defense absorbs veteran losses.

Beats expectations if: QB Davis Warren is efficient, tempo/motion creates explosives, and ILB Matt Rose leads a defense that preserves its stronger traits.

Disappoints if: OL/WR roles stay unsettled, QB Davis Warren remains inefficient, and front/secondary losses pull the defense backward.

Five things to remember

- 1 **? QB question:** QB Davis Warren is the Aug. 29 starter, resolving the opener competition after missing 2025 with injury.
- 2 **2025 baseline:** The 2025 offense was one of the nation's weakest: scoring No.122, total offense No.125, rush offense No.132, offensive success rate No.127 and explosive-play rate No.132.
- 3 **Coaching:** Stanford has an all-new HC/OC/DC structure; Pritchard is the offensive play caller, Terry Heffernan leads the offense structurally and Kris Richard leads the defense.
- 4 **? Defensive availability:** ILB Matt Rose is the defensive anchor, but Stanford loses multiple starters; OLB Wilfredo Aybar's eight-start departure mechanism remains unresolved.
- 5 **Schedule pressure:** SP+ projects 3.8 wins and ranks Stanford No.79 with SOS No.29; the ACC media picked the Cardinal 17th, so bowl contention requires outperforming a broadly pessimistic baseline.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	4-8 (3-5 ACC)	● Poor
Scoring	18.8 PPG	● Very poor
Total offense	306.5 YPG	● Very poor
Rush offense	84.5 YPG · 2.6 YPC	● Very poor
Pass efficiency	6.81 YPA · 14 TD / 12 INT	● Poor
Third downs	37.9%	● Below average
Scoring defense	29.2 PPG allowed	● Below average
Total defense	408.2 YPG allowed	● Below average
Rush defense	119.2 YPG · 3.8 YPC	● Very good
Pass defense	288.9 YPG · 7.79 YPA · 22 TD allowed	● Poor

Stanford's offense was the central problem: it struggled to score, run the ball or sustain efficient possessions. The defense was also below average overall, but a strong run-defense profile was the one clear conventional strength.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	-6.36 · No. 121	● Very poor
Off. EPA/play	-0.074 · No. 98	● Below average
Off. success rate	36.4% · No. 127	● Very poor
Off. explosive-play rate	9.1% · No. 132	● Very poor
Havoc allowed	17.2% · No. 109	● Poor
Opp.-adjusted defense	-2.20 · No. 85	● Average / mixed
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.001 · No. 61	● Average / mixed
Def. success rate allowed	42.6% · No. 79	● Average / mixed
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	11.5% · No. 53	● Average / mixed
Havoc created	14.0% · No. 106	● Poor

Advanced-stat read: Stanford's 2025 offense was not merely low-scoring; it failed in the specific play-level areas that sustain modern offense-success rate No.127 and explosive-play rate No.132-while allowing too much havoc. The defense was more competitive, especially against the run, but opponent adjustment No.85 and havoc created No.106 show that it was not strong enough to carry a broken offense.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC / offensive play caller	♦ Tavita Pritchard - new external HC; play caller	● ↔ Play-calling clarity helps, but immediate improvement remains uncertain.
OC-equivalent	♦ Terry Heffernan - Andrew Luck Director of Offense; new external from Virginia	● ↔ Leads a tempo, shifts/motion and physicality-based structure.
DC-equivalent	♦ Kris Richard - Willie Shaw Director of Defense & Defensive Backs Coach; new external	● ↔ Richard’s emphasis on running/hitting, edge-setting, gap accountability and limiting explosives fits the defense’s relatively better 2025 run/explosive profile, but it arrives amid notable veteran losses.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
♦ QB Davis Warren	Michigan	● ↔ Named opener starter, resolving the competition; missed 2025 with injury.
♦ OL Aidan Kilstrom	Harvard	● ↔ Adds experience to an OL with multiple open positions, but the final five is not established.
♦ WR Nico Brown	Yale	● ↔ Official camp material highlights his prior Yale production and integration; final WR ordering remains open.

Out	To	Loss
QB Elijah Brown	Washington	● ↔ Quarterback turnover is material, but QB Davis Warren has already won the opener job, reducing role uncertainty.
OT Jack Leyrer	Auburn	● ↓ Material OL departure in a unit already coming off the nation’s No.132 rushing offense.
IOL Zak Yamauchi	BYU	● ↓ Another material OL loss amid an unsettled 2026 front five.
WR Myles Libman	New Mexico State	● ↔ Played all 12 and started four in 2025; loss matters more because the 2026 receiver order is not settled.
WR CJ Williams	NFL (Jacksonville), Round 6, No. 203	● ↓ Meaningful 2025 contributor departs as a sixth-round NFL draft selection.
TE Sam Roush	NFL (Chicago), Round 3, No. 69	● ↓ Significant TE contributor departs as a third-round NFL selection, increasing the importance of TE Benji Blackburn’s projected larger role.
QB Ben Gulbranson	eligibility/graduation	● ↔ Substantial 2025 role exits after eligibility; no signed pro destination is established.

Offensive net: ● ↔ role clarity at QB, but continued low-floor supporting-cast transition

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
♦ CB Leroy Bryant	Washington	● ↔ Adds a current corner competition option after major secondary departures; exact order remains undeclared.

Out	To	Loss
OLB Wilfredo Aybar	Roster departure; mechanism/destination not established	● ↓ Eight 2025 starts are absent from the 2026 roster; no transfer, pro or eligibility mechanism is asserted.
CB Collin Wright	NFL (Houston Texans), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Material 2025 contributor leaves via a confirmed Texans UDFA path.
CB Jordan Washington	NFL (Seattle Seahawks), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Meaningful 2025 contributor later signed with Seattle after a rookie-minicamp path.

Out	To	Loss
CB Ché Ojarikre	Duke	● ↔ Significant secondary transfer out adds to corner turnover.
S Mitch Leigber	eligibility/graduation	● ↔ Veteran contributor departs after eligibility; separate pro sweep did not establish a signed destination.
DL Clay Patterson	eligibility/graduation	● ↓ A 12-game 2025 starter leaves the defensive front after eligibility.
LB Hunter Barth	eligibility/graduation	● ↔ Five-game starter departs, reducing experienced depth around ILB Matt Rose.

Defensive net: ● ↓ veteran continuity risk despite a respectable returning-production signal

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Tempo/motion attack with HC Tavita Pritchard calling plays and QB Davis Warren starting.	Clearer structure and a push for more explosives.	2025 efficiency was poor, and WR/OL ordering remains unsettled.
Defense	DC Kris Richard emphasizes edge-setting, gap accountability and limiting explosives.	ILB Matt Rose anchors a unit that was strongest against the run.	Front/secondary turnover is substantial and 2025 havoc was poor.
Special teams	Low-confidence unit with a poor model baseline.	No specific specialist is established as a high-end 2026 anchor.	SP+ special teams No.128 and limited role clarity.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● C+	● ↑	Medium-low	QB Davis Warren has won the opener job, giving Stanford meaningful role certainty.
RB	● C+	● ↑	Medium	RB Micah Ford is the lone returning skill-position starter after a No. 132 rushing season.
WR	● C	● ↔	Low	WR Nico Brown and WR Caden High have roles, but the final order remains unsettled after departures.
TE	● C	● ↓	Medium-low	TE Benji Blackburn takes a larger role after TE Sam Roush leaves for the NFL.
OL	● C–	● ↔	Low	OL Aidan Kilstrom adds experience, but multiple spots remain open after material transfer losses.
DL/Edge	● C	● ↓	Medium-low	DL Braden Marceau-Olayinka is a starter candidate after significant DL/edge start-volume losses.
LB	● B–	● ↔	Medium-high	ILB Matt Rose is the defensive anchor and carries Bednarik/Butkus recognition.
Secondary	● C	● ↓	Medium-low	Stanford loses CB Collin Wright, CB Jordan Washington, CB Ché Ojarikre and S Mitch Leigber.
Special teams	● D	● ↔	Low	SP+ ranks the unit No. 128 with no established specialist advantage.
Coaching	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	HC/OC/DC roles are clear, but all three are new to Stanford and remain unproven together.
Overall	● C	● ↔	Medium-low	SP+ No.79 and a bottom-tier 2025 offense make Stanford a clear Power-4 weakness entering 2026

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through August 24, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Matt Rose	ILB	● High-end defensive starter / team anchor	Bednarik Award · Butkus Award	Entering a second season as a starting inside linebacker with Bednarik and Butkus recognition; the clearest stable high-leverage player on the defense.
◆ Davis Warren (TR: Michigan)	QB	● Projected starter / swing player	-	Named the Aug. 29 starter after missing 2025 with injury. Stanford's offensive ceiling is highly sensitive to whether that role clarity becomes functional efficiency.
Micah Ford	RB	● Returning skill-position centerpiece	-	Official camp material identifies him as the only returning offensive skill-position starter, making him the safest continuity piece in the new offense.
Braden Marceau-Olayinka	DL	● Projected defensive starter	-	Official camp reporting says he figures to start after three 2025 starts; important replacement piece amid front turnover.
Benji Blackburn	TE	● Larger-role projection	-	Expected to step into a larger role after sharing time in 2025; must help replace NFL draftee Sam Roush.
◆ Aidan Kilstrom (TR: Harvard)	OL	● Experienced OL stabilizer candidate	-	Incoming experience matters on a line with multiple competitive positions and major outgoing transfers.
◆ Nico Brown (TR: Yale)	WR	● Transfer receiving upside	-	Camp material highlights his prior Yale production and integration, but final WR ordering is unresolved.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	● Difficult for a team with a sub-.500 model baseline; Stanford has a few plausible home swing games but almost no forgiving FBS road stretch.
Difficulty	● 7/10 · SP+ SOS No. 29
Hardest stretch	at Louisville → bye → at Virginia Tech → at California → SMU
Swing games	Hawaii, Georgia Tech, NC State, at California
Advantage	Two byes split the schedule, and both Georgia Tech and NC State come to Stanford.
Expected	3.8 wins · likely 4-8
Floor / ceiling	2-10 / 6-6

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	SP+ No. 79 and an ACC 17th-place media pick create skepticism; value requires the new offense to beat that low baseline.
Back them when	A meaningful underdog price comes with protection for QB Davis Warren and a matchup suited to the defense's better traits.
Fade/pass when	Opponents can force obvious passing downs or stress the rebuilt secondary.
Key monitor	QB Davis Warren, final OL five, WR ordering, secondary replacements, OLB Wilfredo Aybar replacement and special teams.
Week 1 baseline	vs. Hawaii: no independent preseason fair line; use the live market as the opening benchmark. Live market: Stanford -3.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Stanford should be more coherent with QB Davis Warren named the opener starter and a new tempo/motion structure, but the supporting cast still comes from a very low 2025 offensive baseline. OL and receiver ordering remain the main offensive questions.

ILB Matt Rose gives the defense a proven anchor, yet front and secondary departures lower continuity. The baseline remains **3.8 wins • likely 4-8**, and bowl relevance requires a large efficiency jump rather than simple role clarity.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) • [fall camp](#) • [QB starter](#) • [Aybar bio](#) • [NFL departure](#) • [NFL departure 2](#) • [DC Richard](#) • [play-calling](#)

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